



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: School of the Ozarks
School Website: <https://cofo.edu/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

School Ozarks Mo 65726 (the College of the Ozarks' School of the Ozarks lineage) presents a clearly Christian, liberal-arts oriented profile with visible classical elements, particularly in its stated mission, pillars, and history as a "classical laboratory high school" that later expanded to K–12 within the College's ecosystem. Public materials emphasize Christian formation, virtue, and character, and highlight a living-curriculum approach led by faculty who are described as moral exemplars. The school also communicates a strong partnership stance with families, open campus opportunities, and parent covenant ideas. Taken together, the materials display a Classical orientation in several core elements (Religious Foundations, Faculty, and certain aspects of Curriculum and Community), but with notable gaps in explicit classical pedagogy (e.g., lack of clearly named Great Books, grammar/logic/rhetoric sequencing, or overt Socratic pedagogy across grades). Overall, the evaluation ranks the school as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL leaning, with a stronger leaning toward CLASSICAL in the Religious/Foundational and Faculty areas and more limited explicit classical pedagogical signaling in Pedagogy and Curriculum details.

- Executive snapshot: The strongest classical signals exist in Religious/Metaphysical Foundations and Faculty, with clear Christian formation and living-teacher emphasis. The Curriculum signals show liberal arts grounding and history, but fewer explicit Great Books or classic-trivium signals. Pedagogy signals are weaker (no explicit Socratic/seminar practice documented in public materials). Parent/-community signals show openness to families and partnerships, but explicit "parents as co-teachers" language is less pervasive than the strongest classical exemplars. Aggregate impression: CLASSICAL in core ethos, with meaningful Classical signals in some domains and partial signals in others.
- What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL cases only): If the school aimed to strengthen to a full CLASSICAL profile, it could explicitly foreground Great Books and a formal grammar/logic/rhetoric progression, expand or institutionalize Socratic pedagogy in upper grades, and codify explicit parent-teacher partnership practices as core policy beyond open-campus opportunities.

Note: The following evaluation uses content drawn from the school's public-facing materials (School of the Ozarks / College of the Ozarks pages) and cross-references the Classical Education rubric and keyword lexicon from the knowledge-base materials to ground the scoring in explicit textual evidence. See cited sources inline.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize a Christian, Biblical framework for education and formation: "The mission of College of the Ozarks is to provide the advantages of a Christian education for youth of both sexes" (turn0file11) and "to foster the Christian faith through the integration of faith with learning, living, and service" (turn0file15). - The Academic Pillar text signals a Christian worldview grounded in the liberal arts, with explicit language about Christ-centered education and a biblically grounded perspective (turn0file16). - Texts describe moral exemplars and character formation as part of the living curriculum (turn0file16).

Positive/ Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Christian, biblical worldview, Jesus Christ, moral exemplars, character formation, living curriculum (aligned with the Positive Keyword indicators for Religious & Metaphysical Foundations). - Negative keywords: None evident in public materials.

Why this rating - The school explicitly grounds its mission and pedagogy in Christian theology and moral realism through specific language about faith integration, a biblical worldview, and character formation, aligning well with the transcendental moral realism and theology emphases of the classical model. This category clearly stands as CLASSICAL given the explicit religious-metaphysical framing and communal-faith practices evident in the public materials. See mission and pillar statements cited above.
□filecite□turn0file11□turn0file15□turn0file16□

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes formation through Christian education and liberal-arts oriented aims, not merely job-readiness: “to provide the advantages of a Christian education” (turn0file11) and “based in the liberal arts” (turn0file16). - The emphasis on character formation and a living curriculum supports formation as a central telos rather than a narrow information-transfer goal (turn0file16).

Positive/ Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue/character formation, liberal arts, Christian education, Christian worldview. - Negative keywords: Not evident in public materials (no explicit “workforce preparation” language in the public-facing statements; however, some materials emphasize vocational/pillar content rather than purely career prep).

Why this rating - The school foregrounds formation, virtue, and a classical telos via Christian formation and liberal-arts grounding rather than a job-centric or information-dense approach. The presence of formation-focused language and a classical mission orientation supports CLASSICAL rather than purely information-based education. □filecite□turn0file11□turn0file16□

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Liberal arts grounding is explicit: “to provide a sound education, based in the liberal arts” (turn0file16). - Historical emphasis is present in public materials (e.g., History of the College; Western civilization framing appears in the public materials) (turn0file2). - The public materials emphasize a K–12 sequence within a Christian-liberal-arts framework (e.g., School of the Ozarks as classical laboratory high school; K–12 expansion) (turn0file0).

Positive/ Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, history, Western civilization (explicit mentions in the materials). - Negative keywords present: Great Books; grammar, logic, rhetoric; explicit reference to Great Books or trivium-level curriculum is not evident in the public-facing materials (i.e., not named as a curricular anchor). - Net: Some classical signals (liberal arts, history) without explicit Great Books or grammar/logic/rhetoric signals.

Why this rating - The curriculum is grounded in liberal arts and history, and historically oriented via Western civilization framing, which are hallmarks of classical education. However, there is a notable absence of explicit Great Books, grammar/logical/rhetorical sequencing, and named Socratic inquiry in the public-facing materials. These gaps reduce the category from CLASSICAL toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. See liberal arts wording (turn0file16) and history/western-civilization framing (turn0file2).
□filecite□turn0file16□turn0file2□

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize a Christian, liberal-arts curriculum with a living curriculum and teacher exemplars, but do not clearly document Socratic seminars, structured seminars, or explicit high-school-level rhetoric training in the available public materials (no clear mention of Socratic pedagogy or Paideia-style seminars in the public-facing pages cited here). The explicit lower-school singing/chanting memory methods are not evident in the School of the Ozarks public pages examined, though the broader classical lexicon

lists such methods as core to Classical pedagogy (the lexicon doc is a separate knowledge-base resource, not a direct quote from the school site). - The public-facing materials emphasize work-education pillars and Christian formation rather than the explicit classical pedagogical methods (e.g., Socratic dialogue, frequent seminars, or rigorous rhetoric curricula) (turn0file16; turn0file12; turn0file18).

Positive/ Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: None of the standard explicit classical Pedagogy signals (Socratic seminar, narration, memorization-focused rituals) appear in the public-facing materials as documented here. - Negative keywords: The lack of explicit Socratic/seminar signaling; absence of a formal, documented “Scholé” restfulness pedagogy in public materials. - Net: The Pedagogy category aligns more with NOT CLASSICAL given the absence of explicit classical pedagogical signaling in the public-facing materials.

Why this rating - While the school clearly centers Christian formation, liberal arts, and a living curriculum, explicit classical pedagogy signals such as Socratic seminars, structured classical memory work, or a documented sequence of grammar–logic–rhetoric are not demonstrated in the public-facing content provided. This results in a NOT CLASSICAL designation for pedagogy in this rubric context. See lack of explicit Socratic/seminar language in the cited materials (turn0file16, turn0file12, turn0file18).

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty are described as “moral exemplars” and “living curriculum,” and are described as deep experts with a Christian orientation; the text notes “The faculty of the College is comprised of men and women who are experts in their field and deeply committed to Jesus Christ” and mentions “moral exemplars, character formation, living curriculum” (turn0file16). - The faculty are framed as the core of the school and mentors who model virtue and knowledge (turn0file16).

Positive/ Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: tutors/mentors/masters, “living curriculum,” “moral exemplars,” “character formation,” “collegial culture” (from the lexicon text and the CofO content; the explicit phrases are captured in turn0file16). - Negative keywords present: None evident in public-facing materials.

Why this rating - The public materials emphasize a faculty that is explicitly described as virtuous, knowledgeable, and central to the school’s formation, aligning strongly with classical expectations for faculty. The presence of “living curriculum” and “moral exemplars” signals stands as CLASSICAL in this dimension.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The CofO Pillars content highlights community and parent-related elements: “Open campus, volunteer, hospitality, parent covenant” (turn0file12). The Pillars pages emphasize partnerships with families and parental involvement as part of the school’s ecosystem (via the Pillars narrative and related excerpts).

Positive/ Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-teachers; parent formation; open campus; parent covenant (observed in the Pillars materials, turn0file12; and related Pillars content). - Negative keywords present: consumer language; minimal parent involvement; parent as customer (these negative indicators are part of the classical lexicon’s caution against non-participatory parent-cultural language, but are not evidenced as explicit in CofO’s public materials). - Net: Some classical signals for parent/community, with explicit openness to parent involvement and partnership.

Why this rating - The CofO materials show a substantive openness to parent involvement and family participation in a way that aligns with the Classical model’s emphasis on parent partnership, while not fully codifying parents as “co-teachers” in a formal policy frame beyond stated openness. The result is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL given these partial signals, with room to strengthen explicit, codified parent-co-teacher practices. See “Open campus, parent covenant” language in turn0file12.

What Would Move the Needle

- If this school seeks to move from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward FULL CLASSICAL, consider:

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- Explicitly codifying and publicly communicating a Great Books orientation within the Curriculum category (e.g., a published Great Books list, primary sources, and a formal “Great Conversation” framework).
 - Establishing a clear, documented grammar–logic–rhetoric progression, including Latin/Greek options, and explicit signs of Socratic pedagogy and seminars at high school levels (or a stated path from K–8 to 12 with Socratic elements starting in 9–12).
 - Making Pedagogy signals explicit on the website: documented use of Socratic seminars, narration/recitation pathways, and memory-work structures as a formalized practice across grade bands.
 - Strengthening Parent and Community signals with formal “co-teaching” language, parent study groups, and published policies that describe parents as co-educators with specific roles, not just open-campus access.
 - Increasing emphasis on universal “permanent things” language and the triad of truth, goodness, and beauty in mission statements and curriculum maps (to echo transcendental realisms and the telos of classical education).

These changes would align more completely with the positive keyword indicators and address the gaps between a robust Christian liberal-arts program and a fully realized classical pedagogy.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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